

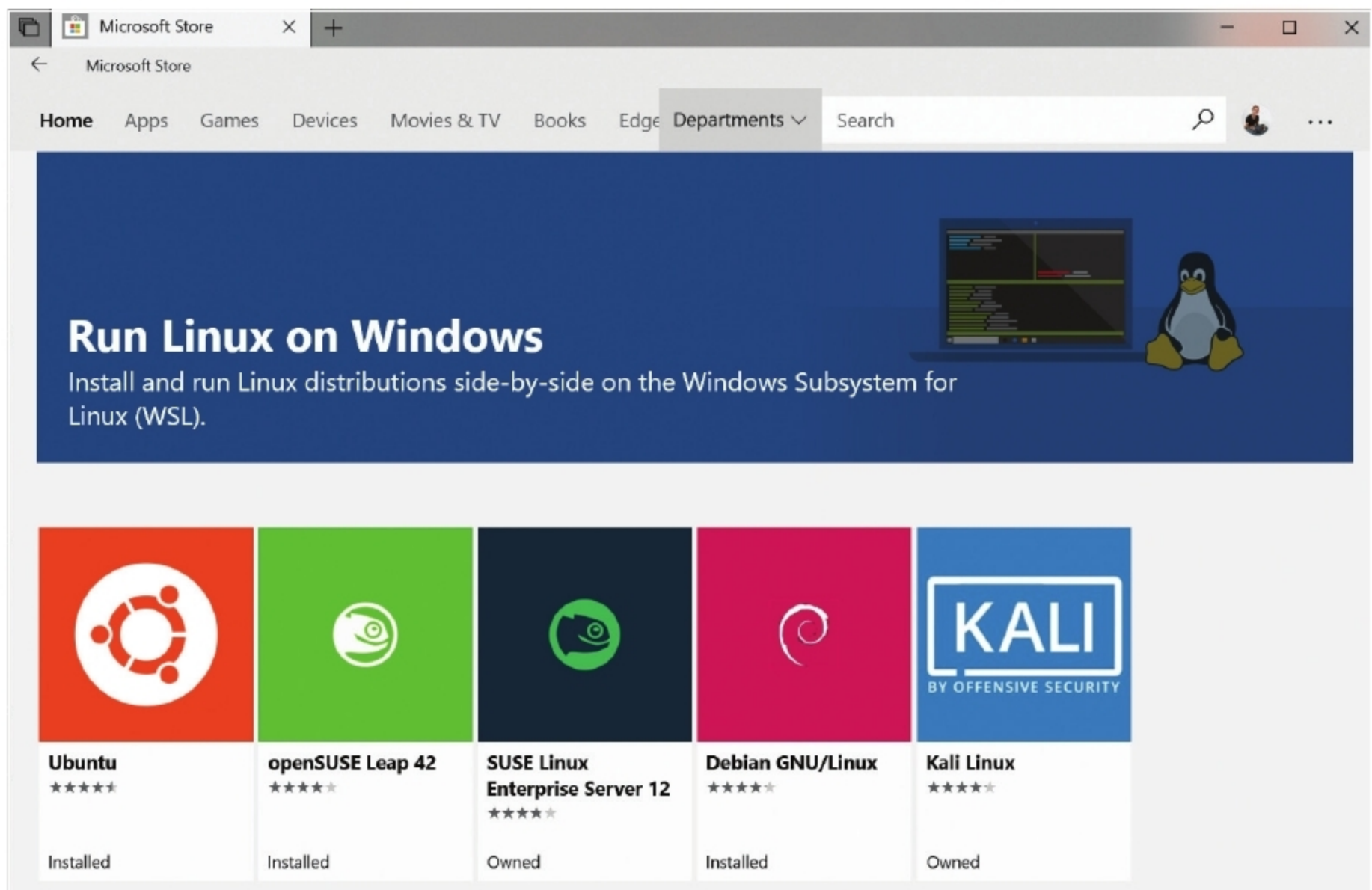


Figure 2: The Windows Subsystem for Linux (Source: Microsoft)

the time of the company's GitHub acquisition and continues as it strives to add support for Linux on Windows. So what exactly is this support and how can regular users make the most of this? Let's take a closer look at this. Running Linux virtually on Windows takes almost no effort but before we get into that, here's a brief introduction to Linux and its variants.

The Linux kernel started out as a project by Linus Torvalds and snowballed into one of the most widely adopted operating systems in the world. As Wikipedia states, it is colloquially used to describe a family of open source UNIX-like operating systems based on the Linux kernel, an operating system kernel first released on September 17, 1991, by Torvalds. Linux is typically packaged in something that is termed a Linux distribution.

Variations on distributions are based on combinations of the Linux kernel

and supporting system software and libraries, many of which are provided by the GNU Project. Popular Linux distributions include Debian, Fedora and Ubuntu. Commercial distributions include Red Hat Enterprise Linux and SUSE Linux Enterprise Server. Desktop Linux distributions include a windowing system such as X11 or Wayland and a desktop environment such as GNOME or KDE Plasma 5. Distributions intended for servers may omit graphics altogether, or include a solutions stack such as LAMP (this is an acronym for the Linux operating system, the Apache HTTP server, the MySQL relational database management system, and the PHP programming language). Because Linux is freely redistributable, anyone may create a distribution for any purpose.

While Linux was originally developed to be used for personal computers based on the Intel x86

architecture, it has since been ported to more platforms than any other operating system. In fact, most mobile phones running Android and its variants are broadly based on the paradigm popularised by Linux. Notably, Linux is the leading operating system on servers and other big iron systems such as mainframe computers, and the only OS used on the Top 500 supercomputers. These facts alone underline how important it might be for developers and users to be able to install and use such a diverse platform. Finally, installing Linux on Windows is now easier than ever!

Virtual machines

Virtual machines refer to the creation of a 'subsystem' within your original operating system from where you are able to boot a new operating system while still working within the parent operating system. Given that a virtual